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Trans Shakespeare

The Serpent and the Wren

Lady Macbeth and Lady Macduff — two characters featured within Shakespeare's *Macbeth* — exist as opposite sides of the same coin. They mirror each other: two women, both married to prominent members of Scottish nobility, with names so similar that it comes as a shock that no characters ever mix the two up over the course of the play. They both have one key difference that draws the line between them, however, and it can be seen in how they interact with their own femininity. Lady Macduff unwillingly conforms to the expectations of femininity thrust upon her; as a wife and mother, she is obligated to care for her family first, even until the bitter end — whether she wants to, or not. Lady Macbeth, on the other hand, does the exact opposite, rejecting her femininity and her womanhood — in turn, suppressing her 'feminine' guilt and fear — for the sake of committing heinous acts in order to advance her status and gain more power over her own situation. That difference between the two and their relationships to their respective expressions of femininity is stark, and an examination of it exposes an awful truth: Whether a woman conforms to her feminine nature, or chooses to discard it, it will still lead her to her inevitable and painful end. It is a disheartening narrative, though it sheds light on greater themes present throughout the work.

Lady Macduff conforms to the expectations of a wife and mother — though, she isn't given much choice in the matter. After all, with Macduff having fled to England (4.1.160), who else is going to take care of their children? "For the poor wren, /" she says, "the most diminutive of birds, will fight, / her young ones in her nest, against the owl" (4.2.11). Lady Macduff, left at Fife by her husband, has essentially been forced to become the wren, thus being forced to conform to the expectation of care he has set upon her. In her anger, Lady Macduff immediately perceives Macduff's flight as foolish proof of a lack of love for his family. "Wisdom?" she questions, as Ross attempts to reason with her. "To leave his wife, to leave his babes, / his mansion and his titles in a place / from whence himself does fly? He loves us not" (4.1.8). Her When Macduff suddenly leaves everything behind, who else is going to take care of his children but his wife? It is in fact this abandonment that spurs Macbeth to "seize upon Fife, give to th' edge o' the sword / his wife, his babes, and all unfortunate souls / that trace him in his line" (4.1.172). In leaving her vulnerable and forcing her into passivity via her motherly obligations, Macduff condemns his wife to death before the murderers even arrive. Just before the slaughter, a messenger arrives to implore her to flee, and she responds thusly: "Whither should I fly? / I have done no harm. But I remember now / I am in this earthly world, where to do harm / is often laudable, to do good sometime / accounted dangerous folly. Why then, alas, / do I put up that womanly defense / to say that I have done no harm?" (4.2.81). Here, she laments the backwards nature of the world that has forced her into passivity. Then, immediately following this monologue, Lady Macduff and her son are slaughtered by the murderers sent by Macbeth (4.2.95) — but her femininity and the passiveness it has forced her to conform to are what lead her to her death. The wings of the bird who was meant to fly were oh so cruelly clipped on the basis of her own nature.

On the other hand, Lady Macbeth attempts to reject her femininity and womanhood altogether. As she prepares to carry out the plan to murder Duncan, she implores the spirits to “unsex [her] here, / and fill her from the crown to the toe top-full / of direst cruelty” (1.5.48). She quite literally asks to be stripped of her own sex, her womanhood, in order to perform this act. It is important to note here that *Macbeth* codes grief, fear, and remorse as very feminine qualities. When Macbeth begins to break down upon seeing Banquo’s ghost at dinner, for example, Lady Macbeth asks her husband the question, “Are you a man?” (3.4.70), as if the presence of his fear and guilt over what he’s done inherently demasculinizes him. So, when Lady Macbeth asks the spirits to ‘unsex’ her, to “make thick [her] blood” and “stop up th’ access and passage to remorse” (1.5.50), the two go hand in hand. To reject any remorse is also to reject her own femininity, done so to commit an act that will in turn grant her and her husband more political power and higher social status. To raise her status like so might lead one to believe that she will avoid the fate of Lady Macduff, but she too unfortunately meets a painful end. She eventually begins to succumb to her guilt, attempting as she sleepwalks to wash the blood of Duncan, Banquo, and all of Fife from her hand. “The Thane of Fife had a wife” she says, referencing the other woman directly. “Where is / she now? What, will these hands ne’er be clean?” (5.1.44). Just as the Thane of Fife’s wife was led to a bitter end on the foundation of her womanhood, Lady Macbeth falls victim to her own feminine remorse, and just four scenes later, she is dead. Despite her attempts to reject her femininity, the “serpent under’t” (1.6.78) falls into the trap of her inevitable, brutal end.

Lady Macduff is forced to conform to her femininity, while Lady Macbeth rejects it — however, they both meet similarly horrific fates. This seems to perpetuate the idea that no matter what a woman does, the very nature of her womanhood will eventually lead her to her downfall. While the idea is incredibly disheartening on a surface level, it serves to contribute to one of the main themes of *Macbeth*: Nobody, no matter how hard they try, can escape their own fate. Your fate as it is destined to be is as deeply engrained within you as womanhood is to a woman, hence the parallels made between these two characters specifically. To be forced into it passively or to reject it actively leads to the same destination. Lady Macduff is senselessly slaughtered, and Lady Macbeth succumbs to the torment of her own mind. Whether the wren, the most diminutive of birds, or the serpent lying underneath the innocent flower, your destiny is inescapable; to reject your fate is to accept your death.

Works Cited

Shakespeare, William. *Macbeth* from The Folger Shakespeare. Ed. Barbara A. Mowat, Paul Werstine. Simon & Schuster Paperbacks, 2013.